

Crash Recovery

When tweaking the BIOS settings, experimenting with the possibilities are the best way to tune your PC for peak performance. But during this process, you might end up pushing it a bit too far—enough to prevent your PC from booting. If this hap-

pens, turn off the computer and wait for at least 7 seconds before switching it back on again. Just as soon as you do this, simply hold down the [Insert] key for a few seconds and the BIOS settings will revert back to their factory set values.

Advanced Chipset entry. Most PCs can safely run this tweak for a small performance increase.

Flash your BIOS

Upgrading your BIOS to the latest version increases speed and stability. It also offers new features and more compatibility to your system. Go to the manufacturer's Web site and download a BIOS flashing utility and a copy of the latest BIOS version specific to your PC. After downloading, make a boot disk and extract the files onto it. To do this, right-click on the floppy drive in Windows Explorer and select Format. Under Format options, click 'Create an MS-DOS start-up disk'. Restart the system and boot from the floppy.

Before flashing, eliminate all possible electrical disruptions. Think twice about this procedure if you live in an area prone to electrical outages. If the flashing process is interrupted, you might have to replace your motherboard.

Accelerating AGP

For those with middle-aged PCs, enable AGP 2x (under Advanced Chipset option) to

double the amount of throughput from your graphics card. Owners of new computers should do the same with AGP 4x. This will deliver higher frame rates in games.

By default, the AGP device waits for two cycles between each data transaction. Reduce this delay to one cycle by making the necessary changes in 'AGP Master 1WS Read/Write' option, usually found in the Integrated Peripherals category.

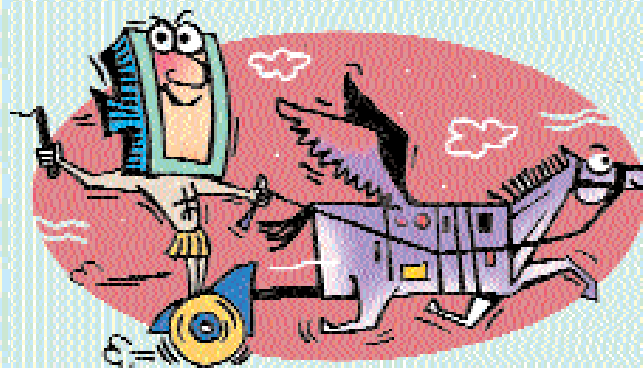
This results in higher graphics performance. Revert to the original settings if you see stray pixels and torn images.

Save memory space and processing power by balancing the amount of system memory needed to store graphical textures. Most new graphics cards come with at least 64 MB of their own memory.

So there is no need to devote more than a few system resources for graphics. Select 'Advanced Chipset' option and move to AGP Aperture Size. Ideally, the AGP Aperture Size should be set between 32 MB and 64 MB.

IN THE DRIVER'S SEAT

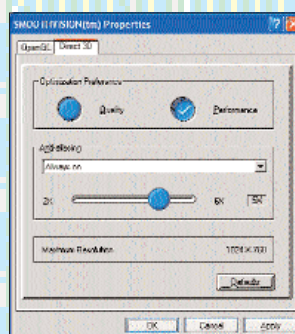
A well-crafted device driver can enhance your hardware's performance



Graphics cards

Look out for graphics driver updates for added performance and features. At times, major driver releases can really push the envelope of graphics performance. If your drivers are more than a

brand of nVidia card you own, always download reference drivers from the brand's site to ensure maximum compatibility and performance. Owners of ATi cards must approach driver updates with caution. For years, ATi products have been plagued with poor driver support—bugs and performance hits have ruled the roost. We recommend downloading only certified drivers. And stay clear of ATi drivers that are still in beta.



ATi has a friendly driver interface

couple of months old, we strongly recommend that you go in for an update.

Owners of nVidia-based video cards can download the unified Detonator drivers that work with all nVidia products from the chipmaker's Web site. No matter what

Disable vertical sync (VSYNC)

If you enable this option, your games will normally run faster as the screen is redrawn irrespective of the monitor's refresh rate. Leaving VSYNC on will result in frames being rendered at a slower rate. Disable VSYNC by clicking on an empty area on the desktop and select 'Properties'. Under the 'Settings' tab, click the 'Advanced' button. Look out for an OpenGL or Direct3D